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His pace, angle and bounce forced England into survival mode before any rhythm had been established. The career-best seven-wicket haul was the consequence rather than the cause.

There was also a deeper tactical deterrent at play. Starc's left-arm angle discouraged England's preferred scoring areas. Batters, hesitant on the drive, were caught between committing fully and playing late.

Brisbane reinforced the pattern. An opening-day six-for on a pitch offering movement again left England chasing the game. By the time Australia reached Adelaide with a 2-0 lead, Starc already had 22 wickets and the Ashes were effectively decided within 11 days. England had not been allowed to grow into the series.

Starc's influence extended beyond the ball. His scores of 77 in Brisbane and 54 in Adelaide, the first back-to-back Test fifties of his career, carried particular weight. Lower-order runs do not just inflate totals. They drain belief. England's bowlers, already struggling for durability, were forced to bowl longer spells with diminishing threat.

Different strokes: While Australia adapted quickly to its reduced resources and found authority elsewhere, England failed to exploit the absences in front of it. GETTY IMAGES

Underlying all this was a stark contrast in fast-bowling resources. Starc, 35, played all five Tests. His speeds held. His role remained clear. Australia trusted him to carry a heavy workload and built its plans around that certainty. England's relationship with pace was far more tentative. Mark Wood's (left) speed was treated as a decisive weapon, but Perth was his first First-Class game in 15 months. Eleven overs later, he was injured and ruled out.

The pattern repeated. Jofra Archer lasted three Tests. Gus Atkinson broke down. By Sydney, England was selecting Matthew Potts, scarcely in the picture earlier in the year. His figures of 141 for none from 25 overs told their own tale, but they reflected a deeper problem. England was improvising while Australia was executing.

What further exposed England's lack of incisiveness was not merely the fragility of its pace resources, but